

JOINING THE FRAY
J&K Apni Party chief Altaf Bukhari (fourth from left) being felicitated at a party workers' meet in Jammu in February

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PDP leaders. Likewise, former Congress leader and ex-CM Ghulam Nabi Azad floated the Democratic Progressive Azad Party (DPAP) in September 2022. It has fielded G.M. Saroori from the Udhampur constituency, where the current MP is Union minister Jitendra Singh of the BJP. Though the DPAP is not expected to challenge the BJP, it can split the vote of the I.N.D.I.A. formation, which has fielded the Congress's Lal Singh, a two-time former Congress MP from Udhampur, who joined the BJP in 2014 and rejoined the Congress in March.

The Sajjad Lone-led J&K People's Conference (JKPC) will resume its old rivalry with NC. Formed in 1978 by former Hurriyat leader Abdul Gani Lone, PC has strong roots in north Kashmir's Kupwara. Lone is the candidate from north Kashmir's Baramulla Lok Sabha seat and is seeking an alliance with 'like-minded' outfits such as Apni Party and DPAP. Such a tie-up can get Lone support from areas like Bandipora and Tangmarg. Though the NC holds the Baramulla LS seat, the BJP has been trying to make inroads in the mountainous areas of Kupwara. Its hope lies with a substantial population of the Pahari ethnic group who were granted Scheduled Tribe (ST) status—and thus reservation in jobs and education—in February. Since then, prominent Pahari leaders like former NC leader Mushtaq Ahmad Shah Bukhari, ex-MLC Syed Mohammad Rafiq Shah and Shehnaz Ganai have joined the BJP.

APNI PARTY, DPAP AND PEOPLE'S CONFERENCE ARE NOT ALLIES YET BUT HAVE COMMON FOES IN THE NC AND PDP. THE LATTER ACCUSE THEM OF BEING PROXIES OF THE BJP

While Apni party, DPAP and PC are not in a formal alliance, they have common political foes in the PDP and the NC. Rhetoric on the ground is sharp. Businessman-turned-politician Altaf Bukhari charges the NC with the alleged rigging of the 1987 assembly election, which many feel triggered armed militancy in Kashmir. In the same breath, he accuses the PDP of selling fake promises when former CM Mufti Mohammad Sayeed replaced the NC-led government in 2002. He also criticised the NC, PDP, CPI(M) and other parties that formed the People's Alliance for Gupkar Declaration (PAGD), a collective of parties formed to fight for the restoration of Kashmir's special status, for having "deceived" the people. DPAP chief spokesperson Salman Nizami says talks are in progress with other parties. "Our agenda is protection for jobs, land, unemployment and statehood. Talks are underway and progress made. Many want Azad should lead the alliance," he says.

The new outfits are expected to eat into the vote share of others, especially the PDP, which has seen an implosion, with many leaders departing after it ended its alliance with the BJP in 2018. In return, the PDP and NC say the new parties are the creation of the BJP to divide society and achieve its 'objectives'. "You see a new kind of politics where outfits like Apni Party peddle the BJP's narrative in a soft manner," says NC leader Aga Syed Ruhullah Mehdi. "The same can be said of the JKPC, which is a committed and sworn ally of the BJP and was part of the previous PDP-BJP government. In a way, they want people to surrender," adds Mehdi. ■